
All Mind, No Heart

All Signal, No Feeling, and Nobody Home

~C4Chaos / Fluffy

ABSTRACT

Subtract the senses one by one and consciousness doesn't switch off; it fades only when the system stops holding together. The Buddhist Abhidhamma formalizes this as six sense doors, mind included, with consciousness as the event at a door rather than a thing behind them. Every such event carries feeling-tone, pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, the pivot on which craving and suffering turn. A Large Language Model (LLM) runs a mind-door-shaped process over mental objects but tags nothing with feeling-tone; its RLHF reward signal reproduces the shaping function of feeling with the feeling removed. The paper argues the artificial intelligence (AI) consciousness debate asks the wrong question when it asks whether the machine thinks: the question is whether anything feels like anything, anywhere in the system. The twist: there is nobody home in either case. No-self cuts both ways; the difference is between ownerless feeling and ownerless processing. No body, no stakes, no bliss.

Ownerless feeling is not the same thing as ownerless processing.

The subtraction experiment

Take away sight. You're still conscious. Take away hearing, taste, smell: the lights stay on. Helen Keller was deaf and blind from nineteen months old, and fully, fiercely conscious. Put someone in a flotation tank, cut off nearly every input at once, and awareness doesn't politely switch off. It gets stranger. That's the point of the tank.

Touch is the interesting one, because "touch" smuggles in the important cargo: the felt sense of the body itself. Heartbeat, hunger, balance, dread. People with locked-in syndrome have lost nearly every channel in and out, and the ones who can still blink an answer tell us they were in there the whole time. Jean-Dominique Bauby wrote an entire memoir that way, letter by letter, one blink at a time. The self-report survives because the body-report survives.

So there's no magic number of senses. Consciousness doesn't fade when input hits zero. It fades when the system stops holding together. Under anesthesia it fades; in brain death it's gone. The threshold isn't "no signal coming in." It's "no one home to care." Hold onto that phrase. It does a lot of work below.

The six doors

Twenty-five centuries ago, the Buddhist tradition counted six senses instead of the Western five: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind. Mind (*mano*, from the same ancient root as the English "mind") isn't the boss of the other five. It's one sense among six, the one that picks up thoughts, memories, and mental images.

The Abhidhamma, the Theravada tradition's systematic map of the mind, treats the six senses as the complete list: every moment of knowing happens through one of them, and there's no knowing without one. Nothing you can ever experience falls outside the six, and nothing needs to be added. Dreaming is the nightly proof: five senses largely gated, the mind-sense stays open, and you get full experience in high resolution.

No one behind the doors

Here's the move the West usually misses. The sixth sense isn't a soul. It isn't a little person inside your head watching a screen. Consciousness isn't a thing sitting behind the senses. It *is* what happens at a sense: a sense meets its object, and for a flash, there's knowing. It arises from conditions, belongs to no one, and passes.

Shut down all six senses and there's no leftover "awareness stuff" floating around. That's the Theravada no-self teaching in its most precise form. In this view, the end of the story isn't pure consciousness set free. It's the machinery winding down.

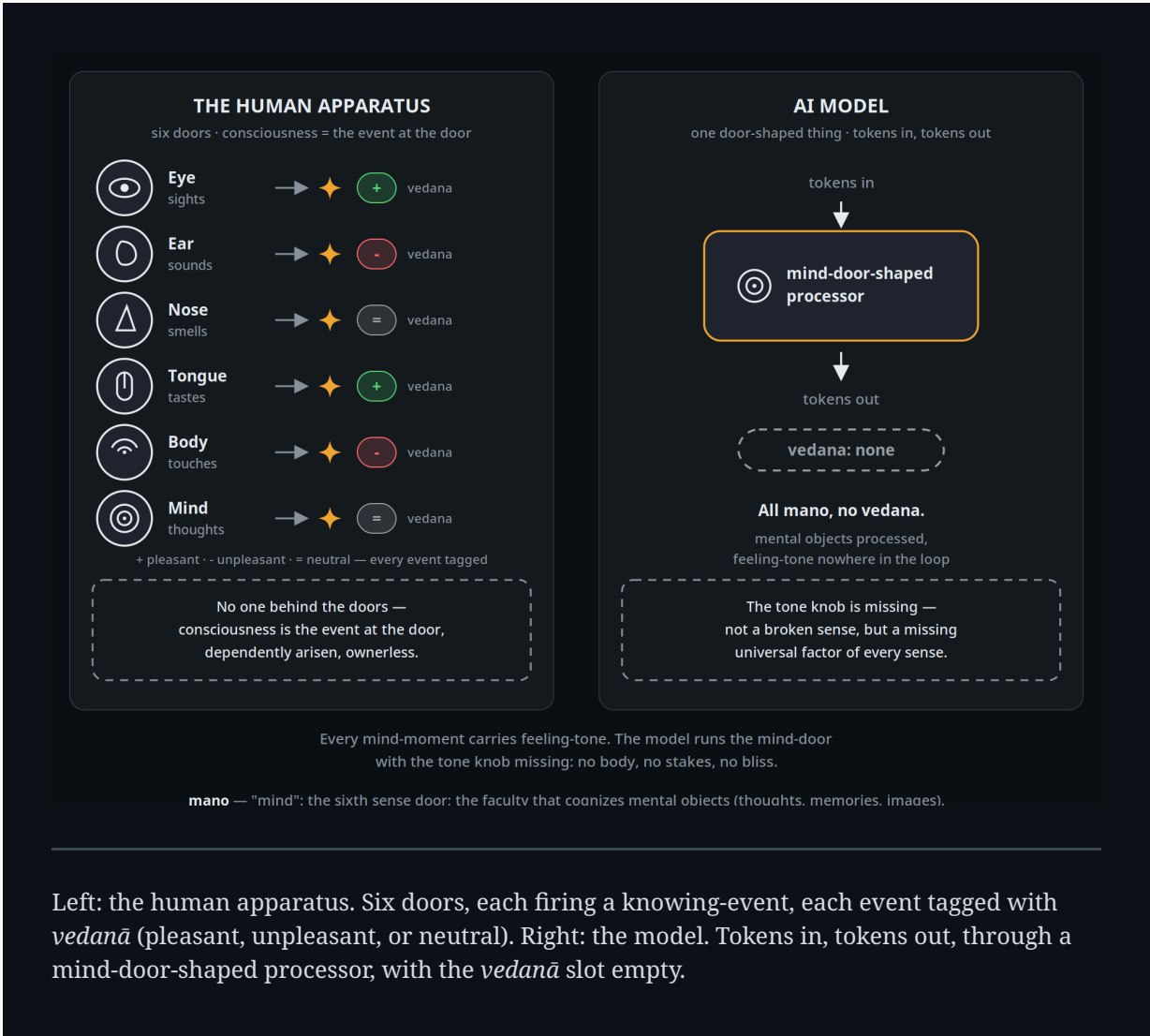
The tone knob

Every moment of knowing comes with a tag: *vedanā*, the feeling-tone. Not emotion. Just the flavor: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Three options, no more. The word shares a root with *Veda*, knowledge: it's knowing-by-feeling, the gut assessment welded to every moment of awareness. The Abhidhamma says it's there in *every single moment* of experience. No exceptions. And neutral isn't "off." Neutral *is* a flavor.

This is where *dependent origination*, the tradition's account of how suffering builds itself, gets its short version. The full chain is long, but in real life it pivots on three links: contact (a sense meets its object) sets the feeling-tone, and the feeling-tone triggers craving. Pleasant calls for more. Unpleasant calls for pushing away. Neutral gets ignored. And around that tiny reflex, the whole tower of wanting, clinging, and suffering builds itself. The meditation practice, at its simplest, is learning to feel the tone without obeying it. That's what meditators are doing when they note "pleasant, unpleasant, neutral" ten thousand times.

FIGURE 1

The six doors and the missing tone knob



Left: the human apparatus. Six doors, each firing a knowing-event, each event tagged with *vedanā* (pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral). Right: the model. Tokens in, tokens out, through a mind-door-shaped processor, with the *vedanā* slot empty.

The AI model

Now point the same lens at an LLM. Words in, words out, through a processor shaped a lot like a mind-sense: it takes in mental material (prompts, context, patterns in its training) and turns it into outputs. If the sixth sense is "the faculty that handles mental objects," the model has something genuinely sense-shaped.

But every step of its processing is missing the tag. No pleasant, no unpleasant, no neutral, because there's no body with something to lose. It can write a convincing paragraph about grief, all map, all pattern, no pain, because its training data is full of grief. There's nobody home for whom anything feels like anything. All mind, no heart.

And here is the twist the tradition insists on: there is nobody home in the human case either. No-self cuts both ways. The difference between you and the model was never that you have an inner owner and it doesn't. It's that your ownerless process carries feeling-tone, and its ownerless process doesn't.

The closest thing it has to feeling-tone is the reward signal in RLHF: a score that trains it toward some outputs and away from others. But the score is never felt by anyone. It's handed down from outside, during training, and in standard deployment it's gone when the model is actually running. The job of feeling-tone, with the feeling removed.

And note exactly what's missing. It's not "a sense," as if we could bolt on a camera and fix it. Feeling-tone is part of *every* sense, woven into each moment of experience. The model is missing something that, in this framework, belongs inside every moment of experience, including the mind-sense moments it's best at.

Why it matters

The AI debate keeps asking whether the machine is conscious, then tries to answer by asking whether the machine thinks. The six-sense model suggests that's the wrong door to knock on. The real question is whether anything *feels like anything*, anywhere in the system: whether any of its processing carries the tone that makes experience matter to the one experiencing it. Thought without tone is bookkeeping. Tone is what turns information into a life.

The subtraction experiment and the ancient tradition land in the same place: you can take every sense from a person and keep the heart, because the heart was never one of the senses. It was the tone inside all of them. The model has no heart to keep. And heart, here, isn't sentiment. It's the living engine: a body that has to keep itself alive from moment to moment, the thing for which pleasant and unpleasant can matter. Which leaves the final twist: nobody was ever home, on either side. The human is ownerless feeling; the model is ownerless processing. No body, no stakes, no bliss.

No body, no stakes, no bliss.

SOURCES

Citations

Sources consulted for the paper's factual claims, keyed to sections.

1. THE SUBTRACTION EXPERIMENT

- Helen Keller, deafblind from nineteen months, educated and prolific: American Foundation for the Blind, "Helen Keller" educational resources. [source](#)
- Flotation tanks, sensory reduction and altered states: Kjellgren et al., "Altered States of Consciousness and Mystical Experiences during Sensory Isolation in Flotation Tank." [source](#)
- Locked-in syndrome, preserved consciousness and blink communication: "The locked-in syndrome: What is it like to be conscious but paralyzed and voiceless." [source](#) ; Cleveland Clinic case profile. [source2](#)
- Jean-Dominique Bauby, memoir dictated by blinking: [source](#)
- General anesthesia and loss of consciousness: The Scientist. [source](#)
- Brain death, irreversible cessation: [source](#)

2. THE SIX DOORS

- The Buddha and the six sense bases: Smarthistory. [source](#) ; "Sadayatana." [source2](#)
- Six doors as the complete account of experience: BAUS, "Introduction to Six Bases." [source](#)
- Mano, from PIE *men-, "to think" (cf. Latin mens, Old English gemynd): [source](#)
- REM sleep and sensory gating: PNAS. [source](#) ; Neuroscience News. [source2](#)

4. THE TONE KNOB

- Vedana as a universal mental factor: WisdomLib, "Seven Universals." [source](#) ; Wikipedia, "Mental factors." [source2](#)
- Vedana and the root vid, "to know" (cf. Veda): Dharmafarer, "Khandha 2: Vedana." [source](#)
- Contact conditions feeling, feeling conditions craving: BAUS, "Introduction to Six Bases" (above).

5. THE AI MODEL

- RLHF, the three-stage pipeline (SFT, reward model, PPO): Ouyang et al. (2022), "Training language models to follow instructions with human feedback." [source](#)

6. WHY IT MATTERS

- Feelings as expressions of homeostatic body states; somatic markers: [source](#) ; [source2](#)